

LEADERSHIP



ANTICIPATION

BEFORE A CRISIS

... how do you allocate resources (trainings, tutorials, guidelines) to expand the room for manoeuvre?

... how do you include future-proofing the technical infrastructure in your institutional strategy?

*In our Forecast Committee, consisting of admin and teaching staff members but also colleagues from other universities, tech companies or from civil society, we had a set budget to develop different teaching innovation pilots. Teaching staff could submit their project ideas so they could get funding. But we did need to make sure that these projects contributed to our university and our strategy in some way. I would say this was our way of future-proofing. And of course, what we learned through these pilots, we tried to translate into trainings etc. for everyone, both as workshops as well as online guides with step-by-step instruction. That way, everyone had the option of advancing his or her teaching.*

... with whom do you collaborate within and beyond your institution for the strategic development of your institution?

... how do you foster creative ideas for teaching and enable cross-unit learning through internal communication networks, spaces and channels?

*In our Forecast Committee, we liked to try out different things. So what we did was pilot teaching projects with partners outside our university like a chatbot for answering admin questions on a course. And if I learned that someone liked being innovative and trying new things, I also approached them to get to know different ideas that could be included in the university's strategy. The annual Day of Teaching was great for that, I had initiated that for teaching staff to share ideas and approaches and learn from each other. And there were so many great new collaborations that came out of it.*

... who drives institutional preparedness the most?

... how do these drivers of preparedness enable creative solutions?

*It was my responsibility to create a vision that incorporated technological advances, especially in relation to digital teaching. I would say, institutional preparedness was driven by our Forecast Committee because this is where we explored different applications for our digital teaching.*



COPING

DURING A CRISIS

... how do you balance different infrastructural needs and demands?

... how do you mobilise and expand resources to open up the space of opportunities to keep teaching going?

*It was not always easy. Because there were some needs we just had to address. Like, we needed an AI policy to clearly outline how AI could be used, what was allowed and what was not. But it was also important to explore the possibilities of AI hands-on, so we also set up our own open-source AI model for lecturers and students to use. The Forecast Committee was really helpful for that. Because we had these close connections with people from the tech sector, who could give us insights and inspired new ideas. But we couldn't talk about AI and not have our own AI system, I'd say.*

... how do you establish coherent lines of communication within and beyond your institution at a moment's notice?

... how do you facilitate collaboration so that creative solutions can be applied quickly across units and faculties?

*While I tried to be as coherent in my communication as possible, it was tough in the midst of a crisis. I did send out all the relevant info mails myself because it was important for people to know that I had it under control. But I also designated a central point of contact for all staff and students, so that everyone always knew who to turn to and where to find for example new guidelines or what was happening with AI at our university.*

... how are ad-hoc decisions made and by whom?

... how are all relevant perspectives involved in decision-making processes to be able to develop creative solutions at a moment's notice?

*When ChatGPT hit, I initiated a crisis team with our IT experts, our teaching & learning centre, our deans – and of course our chancellor to make sure the finances are put in place. Decisions were made together, but as university president, I had to have the last say to try and make things as easy as possible for the deans. Of course, in such a big group, some perspectives were louder than others. But out of the box ideas were just more useful than endless scepticism.*



ADAPTATION

AFTER A CRISIS ... IS BEFORE A CRISIS

... how do you facilitate structured reflection and evaluation of resources and infrastructure implemented during the crisis scenario?

... how do the lessons learned from the crisis scenario affect strategic decisions on infrastructure and resources?

*We are still reviewing what AI infrastructure and resources worked. But I have asked our teaching & learning centre staff to poll experiences with AI tools, what has worked, what hasn't, and whether the tools have actually done what was intended. Once I have the results of this survey, it is my job to decide where we go from here, strategically. What kind of infrastructure do we want and need going forward? What supporting resources do we need and which are obsolete or can be reduced? I mean, we don't need 10 prompting workshops if only one person attends.*

... how do you translate emergency communication practices into institutionalised processes?

... how do you encourage ongoing collaborations across units and faculties to enhance the diffusion of creative teaching solutions?

*With AI now part of our normal lives, we have ceased the crisis team, but now we have our AI Lab. We have so many passionate people at the university, who want to experiment with AI. It's a designated unit that handles all the guidelines, policies and projects around AI. Of course, it's important that people know about the work that is happening there, so I always make sure to include updates from the AI Lab in my monthly uni-wide newsletter.*

... who needs to be involved in the process of consolidating the lessons learned from the crisis scenario?

... how do you review your own actions in terms of initiating and shaping inclusive decision-making?

*From COVID, we have already had a plan of how to create a new normal, so we just used that. And so I bring together different people to review what has worked and what hasn't and how we want to move forward. If I'm being honest, I do ask myself if my decision-making actually is that inclusive. Because listening to critical voices, especially when you are in the weeds of it, is tough, so sometimes, I have to say, I do favour those who share my passion.*

CONTEXT

REGIONAL AND NATIONAL CONTEXTUAL FACTORS

FOR EXAMPLE: POLICIES AND REGULATIONS, FUNDING, DISCIPLINARY CULTURE, FACULTY GUIDELINES, IT ACCESSIBILITY

How do external conditions influence your creative ability to navigate change?

*Being an innovative university is not always easy when I don't have unlimited funding but need to carefully select a handful of pilots that bring the most visibility and insights. And also, higher education systems are not the most flexible, as we all know. So even if someone approaches me with a great project idea, an inspiring new way to use AI productively in our teaching, I still have processes and standards to follow. So, I can't always jump as fast as I would like to.*

IDENTITY

THE INSTITUTION'S SELF-UNDERSTANDING  
FOR EXAMPLE: MISSION STATEMENTS, TEACHING CULTURE, SENSE OF BELONGING, ROUTINES AND PRACTICES OF COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATION

How do the self-understanding of your institution and the corresponding internal dependencies influence your creative ability to navigate change?

*We do have a very open, experimental culture, which is a huge plus. We like being creative and trying new things such as testing digital tools to enhance the participation of different stakeholders worldwide. But of course, there is also resistance to change from some. And this always creates tensions, not just when it comes to AI. And that's why, sometimes, it's just easier to leverage the creative and innovative people and maybe even neglect the naysayers for a second – at least when things are urgent and just need to get done.*